

The Lake

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I can't believe nobody told me about this place. The golden brush is a vastness that looks like it goes for a mile, and its divots and pockets and its squishy-looking marshiness lend it imperfections

uncharacteristic for Stanford. It's a blessed relief, the first not-made-in-a-simulation looking place I've seen on campus. But nobody is looking at the lake. We all came here to look up, and for a while I do, at the little tiny model planes doing loops and spirals and nosedives, controlled by nerdy-looking guy with joysticks on the ground below. My intentions in coming here were to talk to them, to learn more about the Aero/Astro program, to pursue my dream of building rockets and maybe even flying one someday. But it's the first time I've been in an open space in weeks, and I find my attention being pulled to the hills that I'm seeing clearly for the first time, and to the satellite dish perched atop them. I wonder if that yellow grass down there is as tall as it looks.

We came here because it was the stupidest place we could think of to try what we wanted to do. Two of my friends who live on the floor below me in Castaño sit back to back on Matt's boosted board, their knees tucked into their bodies like eggs and their arms linked together. Standing next to me, Matt presses the button on his remote to send them flying down the lakeside path, and in the video I take on my phone all you can hear is me laughing as they rocket away, bump-bump-bumping over the pebbly dirt for less than five seconds before tumbling askew in different directions, into the grass.

The lake is full. My whole freshman year they said it would never fill, but now in my second winter the hills are green and the super bloom is bursting and the lake is full. The water is colder than you can imagine, and I swim alongside my friends as they paddle out to the middle and back on surfboards. I only notice the strange gray lumps by the shore as we're dragging the boards back to land. Looking a little closer, almost against my will, I see that the gray lumps are really gray fur, matted over swollen little bodies. We all look further down the shore, and see them bumping up against the bank, softly sloshing, like little, gray, rodent beach balls. There are dozens of them, the poor drowned rats, caught mercilessly unaware by the atmospheric river that flooded

their homes in the lakebed. I run to Norcliffe and take the hottest shower of my life.



I've been hanging out in a West Lag dorm recently, partly because it's near the lake, my favorite dining hall, my work at the Outdoor Center, but mostly because that's where a close friend who's been pulling at my heartstrings lives. It's the evening, and I'm trying desperately to feign excitement for him as he tells me about how he went salamander hunting the night before around the lake with a girl, searching together in the brush after dark, fueled by their shared love of the earth and its creatures. I go home and stalk her Instagram and LinkedIn.

I never run, but I'm running now as fast as I can with two and a half Coors Banquets sloshing in my stomach. I came here to say goodbye to a friend before he goes abroad, but I didn't expect to get roped into a beer mile (a Liquidy Lag Lap, to be precise), disguised as a going away party. He's a newer friend, and I probably wouldn't even have come except I like spending time with him more than I thought I would. It's too bad he's leaving for the spring, since we probably would have turned into good friends if he'd stuck around, but I showed up for his Liquidy Lag Lap anyways and now me and my friend Emily are passing a beer back and forth, looking at each other in self-pity as we will ourselves to swallow, put our heads down, and stagger forward down the lake path towards the finish line.

Drenched in the heat of senior spring, I sit on a bench with that friend, now my best friend, who I have been in love with for some time. I'm staring at the sunlight filtering through the reeds in the lakebed below, at the wooden grains on the bench between us, at anything but him as I listen to his voice tell me that despite our recent evenings together, he can't give me anything more than friendship while he tries to process the fact that his freshly-ex-girlfriend, who had also had been one of his closest childhood friends, no longer wants anything to do with him. The words register in my brain, and I try to decide whether to let them sink into my heart.

I knew that if I were ever to have a graduation party, it would be here. Lexi's mom brings a boatload of Stanford-themed decorations and I

pick up the cake from Lexi's favorite spot, decorated semi-ironically with a Taylor Swift quote: "You're on your own, kid." It's cheesy and sweet, and it's a beautiful evening, and my whole family is here. Michael comes too with his family, and Oriana and I swing dance together to the music I'm playing from my little JBL Flip speaker, and the evening is perfect because all I wanted from my family's visit for graduation was to show them the lake at golden hour, and the lake delivered.



I'm running, like I do often these days, floating on the newfound lack of pain in my shins. After three years of running with the dull ache of microfractures in my tibia, the absence of it now makes me feel like my

legs are made of titanium. On my way down the short, steep downhill that marks the start of the clockwise direction around the lake, I pass a friend coming the other way who also left the frisbee team because of an injury, also though her departure was a few years before mine. We lock eyes and hers are already smiling, and my heart soars because I know she knows the torture of a run-walk progression, I know that this lake has felt both pairs of our legs shuffle around it over the years, and I know that now her ACL is strong enough to send her flying around this lake as many times as she wants, just as my legs can now do for me. My head is up and my eyes are forward and I am grateful, and I continue to run.